

“I don’t want to take him out,” I said. “I want to take *you* out!”

I was persistent. For months I kept asking, always getting the same response. “Can’t. I’m already seeing someone.” Then I stopped asking for a few weeks, and—wouldn’t you know it—that’s when she got a little bit interested.

My roommates and I were throwing a huge party and, unbeknownst to me, Linda got herself on the invite list through one of my friends. We hit it off immediately, just like I knew we would. After that night, Linda and I were an item. The other guy she’d been dating was toast.

Our courtship was very simple. There were no lavish dinners, no decadent vacations, no luxury cruises and weekend shopping trips to Paris. Linda and I were united in a common purpose: to enjoy our time together without worrying about our finances. We spent most of our time with three other couples, and the eight of us watched movies on the third floor of my house; we ordered takeout from Mr. Pong’s, the best (and most economical) Chinese food in Toronto. We hosted backyard barbecues—hot dogs, hamburgers, cheap beer and wine. It was nothing fancy. Linda was a student and I was just starting my business. We didn’t have a fortune, but we did have fun.

Linda and I dated for six years before we got married. We broke up once in the middle before getting back together a few months later. By the time we finally tied the knot, we had doubled Georgette’s Three-Year Rule. We weren’t starry-eyed kids rushing full tilt down the aisle. We had tested our relationship, figured out our core compatibilities and made a plan for a partnership that would last. The fact that we are still married 24 years later means we must have done something right.

Money Mistake: *You Don’t Know Your Partner*

The Fix: *Perform Relationship Due Diligence*

I would never put my money into a business without doing due diligence first. If I’m interested in something I’ve seen on *Dragons’ Den* or *Shark Tank*, I vet the company thoroughly before I part with